Overall Reflections

Civil society members saw the Bharat Jodo Yatra as an opportunity to safeguard democracy and India's constitutional fabric. The Congress party's leadership was respectful and ensured civil society was given dignified space (especially since, while affiliated with the Yatra, they maintained their distinct identities and carried their own banners and flags). But the party has its own logic and concerns, which is why the organizers were busy managing the Yatra's media, social media, security, route, rest, food, accommodation, interactions, the well-being of the yatris and coordination with state units. SBF complemented this by acting as a bridge between civil society and the party. In fact, many yatris had a limited understanding of why civil society was walking in what they saw was a Congress Yatra. I quietly facilitated conversations and discussions with different Congress yatris. Thanks to these efforts, gradually Congress yatris began to see civil society as ideological allies.

The Congress party undoubtedly mobilized its cadre in every state. But they were only a fraction of the people who turned up from faraway villages and towns to join the Yatra just out of love for India. Wave after wave of lakhs of people kept coming in. Some came for a day or two, or a week. Others stayed longer. Some young adults ran away from their homes to join the Yatra. And our teams, whether in Delhi or on the ground, had to accommodate every single person patiently and warmly. I can say with 100 per cent certainty that those thousands of intellectuals, artists, writers, activists, community leaders, professionals and individuals from different regions who joined the Yatra changed their views about the Congress party, largely because of our collective sincerity and organizational competence. Each one of us also worked hard for our own individual benefit, because we were so hungry to learn and connect with all these people. But it also helped the party tremendously.

Having said that, there were some aspects of civil society that I found shocking. One group alienated grassroots organizations and people, as they did not feel comfortable merging their identity with any other organization.